performance full, immediately put Kashmir under a military siege. A country that needs to impose a curfew every time it fears what it calls ‘unrest’ in a region that it claims as an integral part should by now have learned that it is not an integral part. It never was.

It was not just the hanging but also the manner of it—executed while the world slept, in secret and in great haste, as thieves do when they embark on their dark deeds—that makes this execution a symbol of the deep moral rot at the heart of the Indian state. Indian authorities chose not to inform Afzal Guru’s family prior to the hanging and quietly buried him in prison. His brother has said they learned of his execution on TV. A letter sent by the Government of India to Afzal Guru’s wife reached her two days after the execution. Even the public prosecutor responsible for Afzal Guru’s trial has admitted that it was a violation of his rights as well as of India’s prison manuals that state a person on death row must be allowed family visits.

What kind of state makes sure that the wife and young son of a man it is about to execute do not see him, touch him or hear him talk, one last time? Kashmiris, in mourning and in fury, erected a tombstone over an empty grave in the main martyrs’ graveyard in the Kashmiri capital, Srinagar. The text of the epitaph was the same as that of another epitaph, erected in memory of Maqbool Bhat, the founder of Kashmir’s main pro-independence militant group turned political formation, the Jammu and Kashmir Liberation Front, who was hanged in the same jail twenty-nine years ago. The epitaph reads, ‘The martyr of the nation, Mohammad Afzal Guru, Date of Martyrdom: 9th February 2013 Saturday, whose mortal remains are lying in the custody of the Government of India. The nation is awaiting its return.’

On the morning of 13 February, Kashmiri news websites reported that the police had removed and destroyed the tombstone and then, after the news spread via Twitter and Facebook, a replacement tombstone mysteriously reappeared. The Kashmiri phrases Qabr Chhoor and Kafan Chhoor, titles for those who rob graves or shrouds, are deployed to describe the basest of thieves. The swiftness of the execution, and the macabre theatre that followed, which included an offer by the Indian government that Afzal’s family will be allowed to pray once by his grave in prison, which the family promptly turned down, is disturbingly reminiscent of Franco’s Spain.

I learned of the execution in London and struggled to make sense of it. I still do. It was, for reasons moral and legal—judicial review is available to even people denied a presidential pardon—somehow unbelievable, although